

IT'S NOT ONLY "WHO YOU KNOW" THAT MATTERS Gender, Personal Contacts, and Job Lead Quality

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Previous research has shown that personal contacts are powerful intermediaries in transmitting job lead information for both job seekers and employers and therefore could contribute to various forms of gender inequality by, for example, providing higher-quality job leads to men than to women. The authors use a unique data set that includes information on the quality and source of individual job leads to explore whether the overall quality of job lead information depends solely on various attributes of recipients' contacts or whether job lead quality is also conditional on gender. These data are based on a diverse sample of professional, technical, and managerial workers from California. Findings indicate that the overall quality of the respondent's job leads is a product of their gender and that of the person providing the lead. In addition, net of a variety of factors, women and men with young children at home receive significantly lower-quality job leads.

Several generations of researchers have investigated the role of ascriptive characteristics such as gender and race in shaping how individuals are matched with jobs. Generally, variation in how people search for jobs, whether by using information gleaned from personal contacts or more formal means, has been linked to diverse outcomes such as job loss (Eby and Buch 1994; Kanfer and Hulin 1985), turnover and reemployment (Kirschenbaum and Weisberg 1994; Wanberg, Watt, and

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Rumsey 1996), and psychological outcomes including self-esteem and perception of workplace control (Ellis and Taylor 1983; Saks and Ashforth 1999). Recently, the role of contacts has also been investigated in shaping hiring decisions (Fernandez and Weinberg 1997) and opportunities for social mobility in the workplace (Podolny and Baron 1997). The use of personal contacts in a job search continues to generate interest as a source of gender disparities in important employment outcomes such as occupational sex segregation, status, and earnings (Beggs and Hurlbert 1997; Brass 1985; Campbell 1988; Drentea 1998; Ibarra 1997; Leicht and Marx 1997; Mencken and Winfield 2000; Straits 1998).

To what extent does gender influence the transmission of job-related information between two people? Is the quality of job leads that people receive purely a matter of who provides the lead, or is the quality of the lead also influenced by characteristics of the recipient, such as the recipient's gender? In this research, we address the usefulness of personal contacts as a source of job information by examining how the quality of job leads varies according to the gender of the provider of the lead, the gender of the recipient, and the interaction between the two. We focus on whether important features of individuals' contacts provide varying degrees of advantage (or disadvantage) to women and men. We extend the literature on gender, personal contacts, and employment by examining the transmission of job leads as a potentially gendered social process. This focus on the quality of job lead information allows us to contribute to research efforts on gender and the use of work-related personal ties, and gender-based inequality at work more generally.

We proceed by directly examining differences in the quality of job information that passes through the personal contacts of female and male professional, technical, and managerial workers. We are interested in whether men's and women's personal contacts are equally useful in terms of the quality of job leads they provide. An innovative strategy we employ in this study is to focus on the overall quality of job leads a person receives rather than only the lead that resulted in a successful hire. Specifically, we address whether differences in the quality of job information can be explained by (1) gender differences in the characteristics of work-related contacts that are likely to result from disparities in men's and women's structural location in both the labor market and occupational hierarchies and (2) the gender of the job lead recipient. By attending to differences in job lead quality between men and women and their contacts, we speak to both the "who you know" part of our question and the "who you are" dimension.

These questions are important to the study of gender because they address how work-based inequality is shaped by gender at multiple sites of social organization. On one hand, women may be disadvantaged structurally within organizations because of the sex segregation of jobs and are thus denied access to men's work-based social networks, which are also sex segregated. The sex segregation of jobs and occupations may be both a cause and a result of segregated work-based networks. On the other hand, previous research has paid significantly less attention to the micro-level social processes involved when job-related information is exchanged between women and men. Our contribution is to examine both by

analyzing a unique sample of male and female professional, technical, and managerial workers. Although our sample is nonrandom, it nevertheless marks a significant improvement over currently available data sources in several important respects, which we outline below. For instance, few studies on gender, job search, and personal contacts have examined professional-technical-managerial workers (either men or women) from a broad range of jobs or populations of exclusively professional-technical-managerial women. An even smaller body of research has benefited from data that directly describe both the quality of job lead information gleaned through contacts and various attributes of both the provider and the recipient of job leads.

PRIOR RESEARCH ON WORK-RELATED CONTACTS

Research on gender, contacts, and job searches emphasizes how structural features of the workplace, along with men's and women's locations in the opportunity structure of organizations, affects the quality of job information transmitted through the personal contacts of both women and men (Ibarra 1993). This literature shows that gender is related to both network composition and effectiveness in securing job-related information (Campbell 1988; Hanson and Pratt 1991; Straits 1998). Regarding contact status, women's social networks have more kin than do men's networks (Bott 1971; Fischer 1982; Marsden 1987; Moore 1990; Wellman 1990). In contrast, men's networks tend to have more work-related contacts with relatively few kin (Moore 1990). However, Moore (1990) demonstrated that most of the gap is attributable to differences in age, marital and work status, and the number of young children in the household. In addition, because women continue to allocate more time and effort to household and child care duties (Berk 1988; Bianchi et al. 2000; Gupta 1999; Presser 1994), women's personal contacts also tend to be less diverse than men's.

Because men and women often hold different job titles, even when employed at the same establishment and performing similar work duties, they are often physically separated from one another (Bielby and Baron 1986; Carrington and Troske 1998; Reskin 1993; Tomaskovic-Devey 1993). This has consequences for the characteristics of men's and women's networks. Campbell (1988) found that women's personal contacts tend to come from a narrower range of occupations than do men's, reflecting the sex segregation of jobs and occupations. The gendered nature of the workplace also affects both interpersonal relationships and the organization of work roles that inhibit the development of cross-sex work-related relationships (Straits 1996). For example, social norms may constrain the development of cross-sex contacts in the workplace (Feiring and Coates 1987). Cross-sex friendships with coworkers and associates may elicit intense scrutiny and sanctions from supervisors and coworkers, particularly as these relationships often extend outside normal work routines. These relationships may therefore be too costly to pursue and will be dropped in favor of ones deemed more gender appropriate. Alternatively,

some have explained sex-segregated networks by arguing that women are intentionally blocked from joining men's work-related networks to exclude them from well-paying jobs and to minimize the perceived threat that the status and pay of men's jobs will decline as women enter them (Reskin 1993; Reskin and Padavic 1994). Therefore, men's and women's differential use of instrumental (work-related) contacts may be a product of the gendered nature of work and organizational hierarchies that inhibit cross-sex contacts (Kanter 1977; King 1992; Leicht and Marx 1997).

Regardless of whether the source of gender differences in the composition of work-related contacts is primarily structural or dispositional, men's and women's career trajectories may be affected by those differences. For example, Drentea (1998) argued that women are vulnerable to being channeled into low-wage, female-dominated jobs by using personal contacts in a job search. Since women tend to have female-dominated networks, acting on job information provided by those contacts may sustain occupational sex segregation and, consequently, earnings inequality. Similarly, Hanson and Pratt (1991) found that women who were employed in female-dominated jobs tended to use other women as sources of job information, and Mencken and Winfield (2000) reported that women are less likely to be employed in a female-dominated job when men are included in their networks.

Sex-segregated networks become more consequential when one considers the high frequency with which contacts are used to locate job opportunities. For example, Leicht and Marx (1997) showed that nearly half the applicants hired by a bank were told of the job by a relative, friend, or business associate. A comparable (and in some cases, larger) percentage has been found elsewhere (e.g., Elliot 1999; Green, Tigges, and Diaz 1999). Not only do job seekers rely heavily on information conveyed through word of mouth, but there is some evidence that contacts provide job seekers with better information about jobs (Granovetter 1974; Wegener 1991) and help job seekers locate openings more quickly than do formal methods (Wielgosz and Carpenter 1987).

Previous research has documented important differences in women's and men's job-related networks and has attempted to uncover the sources and consequences of those differences. We take a different tack by examining the extent to which the overall quality of job leads that pass through men's and women's contacts is influenced by the characteristic attributes of who is giving the leads, who is receiving the leads, and the interaction of both types of attributes.

Gender, Jobs, and Contacts: Is It Who You Know or Who You Are?

Research using a social networks perspective suggests that ascribed characteristics of the job seeker, such as gender, are important only insofar as they condition the structural factors that ultimately influence the quality of job-related information that flows through personal networks. The influence of the recipient's gender on the quality of the job leads he or she receives is indirect through factors such as the sex

and status composition of personal networks to influence the quality of job leads. This line of inquiry is extended by the work of Lin, Ensel, and Vaughn (1981) and Lin and Dumin (1986), who argue that individuals' access to high-status occupations is influenced by the composition of their social networks.

For example, men might receive more desirable job leads than women do simply because men tend to hear about leads from other men (due to the high degree of sex homophily in men's networks), who in turn have access to better job-related information than women (due to men's superior position in the occupational structure). Thus, occupational and job-level segregation fosters same-sex or homophilous networks, resulting in better job leads accruing to men. This is a purely structural explanation—a man and a woman who receive job leads from contacts who are the same with respect to sex will receive leads of equal quality. Stated differently, this implies that any gender gap in the quality of job leads received by men and women should be explained by who is offering the leads.

In contrast to social network theory, status construction theory highlights the direct effect of ascriptive characteristics by positing that individuals take sex (and other visible characteristics) into account when forming work-related contacts and passing along information about jobs.¹ For example, Ridgeway (1997) and Ridgeway et al. (1998) have described the salience of cultural beliefs and gender stereotypes that lead to both the devaluation of women's attributes and the assumption that women are less competent than men (see also Deaux 1985; Eagly 1987). Ridgeway (1997) has argued that the relationship between gendered organizational arrangements and inequality is mediated largely by interactions among workers, which are guided by gendered status beliefs. As McGuire (2000, 504) suggested, because individual network resources differ by gender, others may assume that gender accurately reflects their ability and competence to perform certain work roles. Importantly, these beliefs constructed around gender may disadvantage women with respect to their social contacts. For example, women may be excluded from important work-related personal networks. Worse yet, the network rewards accruing to women may be lower than those benefiting men in similar positions in organizational hierarchies and with similar constellations of credentials and resources (McGuire 2000).

Toward a Synthesis of Structure and Interaction

A synthetic approach to the problem of job information exchange assumes that the process depends not only on the attributes of the pool of individuals providing the leads but also on the sex of the recipient: Men possess both better job-related information and more male contacts than women, but job lead quality may also depend on the recipient's sex, net of the characteristics of his or her network. Simply stated, all else being equal, men might give better tips to men than to women. Similarly, Ridgeway (1997) suggested that women are not immune from these status value beliefs; thus, according to this perspective, women might also give better job lead information to men than to women.

This adds a micro-level, interactional component to the structural explanation—gender differences in the quality of tips received are not reducible to who is providing the leads. This implies an interaction between the recipient's gender and the sex composition of his or her job-related contacts and points to the process by which an individual's beliefs about a job seeker's worth and appropriateness for certain kinds of work are inferred from the job seeker's gender (Ridgeway 1997). For example, a male job lead provider might be reluctant to pass on a high-quality job lead to a woman because of his gendered assumptions about her nonwork (e.g., family) obligations and/or level of career commitment. Acker (1990) pointed to the gendered nature of work organizations by showing how the workplace tends to privilege masculine attributes that are embedded in organizational practices—men may also reproduce male advantage in how they distribute job leads. This suggests that the usefulness of one's personal contacts as a source of job information is conditional on his or her gender and not solely on the composition of the network used to accrue job-related information.

DATA, MEASURES, AND MODELS

The Sample

Data sets appropriate for investigating the gendered nature of the passing of job leads are uncommon. Large, representative data sets used to document gender differences in the use of job search methods (e.g., formal versus informal) and the extent to which gender differences explain outcomes such as sex segregation and earnings inequality (e.g., see Drentea 1998; Green, Tigges, and Diaz 1999) are devoid of information about both the quality of the lead and the person from whom the lead came. When such information is available, the data typically describe specific organizational settings (e.g., McGuire 2000), which raises questions about the generalizability of the results. Other researchers (e.g., Mencken and Winfield 2000) interested in the issues we address have been forced to rely on data collected as far back as the early 1980s, further illustrating the relative scarcity of appropriate data for examining the questions we ask.

We overcome many of these limitations by using data from a 1997 survey of members of the Experience Unlimited job clubs located throughout California. These clubs are affiliated with the state Employment Development Department (EDD) and are designed to aid professional, technical, and managerial workers in locating employment opportunities.² Membership is voluntary and contingent on unemployment resulting from a company layoff and having work experience that is considered professional or mid to upper white collar. In the late 1990s, the state EDD funded 26 job clubs throughout California. The clubs offer us an excellent opportunity to survey workers from a broad range of occupations and industries.

At the time of our study, individual club membership ranged from less than 20 to approximately 200. To facilitate data collection, we contacted the designated EDD

coordinator of each club inquiring if they would participate in our survey. The EDD coordinators acted as liaisons between the researchers and club members. This strategy resulted in the participation of 23 of the 26 clubs initially contacted.³

During preliminary discussions with EDD club coordinators, we gathered information on each club's total membership and average weekly meeting attendance. Each coordinator was mailed enough questionnaires for his or her entire membership and instructions for completing the surveys that were to be administered at the next club meeting.⁴ Although attendance at meetings is strongly encouraged—in fact, it is mandatory—not every member can attend each meeting. We obtained surveys from approximately 60 percent of the 23 participating clubs' average weekly or monthly attendance.⁵ Our sample consists of 524 respondents, 324 (62 percent) of whom are men and 200 (38 percent) of whom are women.

Our respondents come from health care, banking, aerospace, manufacturing, utilities, government, education, agriculture, and advertising, reflecting California's diverse industry and service base. Respondents' job titles include corporate vice president, consultant, administrator, manager, director of sales/marketing, project manager, technical writer, program analyst, various kinds of engineers (civil, mechanical, computer, and electrical), environmental scientist, and several chief executive and chief financial officers.

Although our sample has several notable advantages over data used in existing studies, some shortcomings should be acknowledged. First, because respondents are members of a voluntary organization, they may differ from nonmembers in important ways. For example, those who voluntarily join a job club might do so because they have limited, or otherwise poor, network connections; however, in personal interviews with club members, we found many to be active in their communities and with well-established social networks. It is also possible that people who join job clubs may in fact be better connected than the average individual as a result of their high likelihood of belonging to other clubs as well (i.e., people who join might be atypically social people who join a disproportionately large number of clubs). Membership in a voluntary organization, therefore, may be a potential source of sample selection bias. An important question then is, How likely is it that the self-selection of respondents into the Experience Unlimited job clubs resulted in a sample that differs from the broader California labor market of professional, technical, and managerial workers? Comparisons with California workers taken from the Current Population Survey (March 1997 file) suggest that those in our sample are comparable on several key variables to those in that nationally representative sample.⁶ Although inferences from our sample should be made cautiously, this does not diminish the usefulness of the sample for exploring the extent to which gender and gender pairings between recipients and providers of job leads structure the transmission of job information. This point is underscored by the fact that data sets used in prior studies of gender, contacts, and job information are often limited to specific organizational settings or subpopulations. In addition, to the extent that gender stereotypes defining appropriate and inappropriate work roles are widespread and stable across both time and place (Heilman 1995; Williams and Best

1990), it is highly probable that any gendered process we uncover will operate among other segments of the larger labor market as well.

Dependent Variable

To assess one dimension of the overall quality of information that passes through their personal contacts, our respondents were asked to describe up to three job leads they recently received, even those leads that they did not pursue. Although respondents were unemployed at the time of the survey, they were asked questions about job leads received while they were employed.⁷ Specifically, they were asked, "Over the last few years *while you were employed in your last job*, did a contact ever alert you to a job opening in your field, whether you pursued the job lead or not?" We asked the question in this way because we wanted the respondents to exclude those leads they might have received while participating in the EDD job clubs. This exclusion is important because the job club activities, such as sharing job leads with other members, are different from the gendered dynamics that occur in work settings. Following prior research on weak ties and employment (e.g., Granovetter 1974), we also instructed respondents to exclude job leads received from family members.

If at least one lead was received, respondents were then asked to provide the annual salary of each lead. Although we acknowledge that job quality is a multidimensional concept, we use annual salary of the job lead to describe the quality of the associated job. A more nuanced measure of job quality might have included asking respondents to describe other attributes of the job lead received (such as the benefit structure, job security, and/or promotion opportunities). However, this strategy would have introduced an unacceptable amount of measurement error since that is information respondents may not have. Therefore, we opted for the simpler measure rather than relying on a poorly measured multidimensional concept. While most would agree that salary accounts for a substantial amount of variation in perceived job quality (see Rowe and Snizek 1995), the transmission of job leads may be affected by the varying valuations of jobs that may differ by gender, and job characteristics (other than salary) may be a substantial part of these assessments.

Our aim is to assess the quality of job lead information that passes through men's and women's networks. This includes job leads that are pursued as well as those that are not.⁸ A limitation in studies of contacts and job information is that almost all inquire only about the lead that the respondent successfully pursued. By asking about all leads, we get a fuller assessment of the kinds of information that contacts chose to tell men and women. We conceive of job leads as personal invitations to explore opportunities; for our purposes, it does not matter whether an invitation was accepted or not.

We minimize recall-based measurement error by limiting our queries to three job leads. Meta-analyses (e.g., Brewer 2000) of recall in social network studies show that respondents generally have poor recall of weak ties, which increases with the number of ties reported. Our survey was designed to strike a balance between

maximizing the amount of job lead information received and minimizing recall bias by asking respondents about no more than three contacts/leads. Because we are interested in the overall quality of job leads, we use the mean salary of the job leads provided to each respondent (the sum of the job lead salaries divided by the number of leads received) as our dependent variable. In our sample, approximately 40 percent of respondents received one job lead, 25 percent received two leads, and 35 percent received three leads. Because our dependent variable is an average, skewness was minimal (which is often not the case with other forms of income or earnings). As a result, a logarithmic or other transformation of the dependent variable was unnecessary. Our multivariate results are expressed in the original metric (actual dollar returns to various characteristics of the respondents and their pools of lead providers).

Independent Variables

Characteristics of tip providers. For each job lead reported, respondents were asked to describe several characteristics of the person who provided it. Specifically, each respondent was asked about the gender and relationship status of each tip provider—whether the contact was a “co-worker,” “work-related contact,” or “social acquaintance.” Again, respondents were instructed to exclude family and job club members. The type of contact is an important control variable because social acquaintances may provide more nonredundant information than work-related contacts. In addition, we want to isolate the effect of the lead providers’ gender from confounding factors such as the type of contact.

We used this information to compute the sex composition (percentage female) of each respondent’s pool of job lead providers. Because this pool cannot comprise more than three individuals, its sex composition can take the following values: 0 percent female, 33 percent female, 50 percent female, 67 percent female, or 100 percent female. We also control for the number of work-related providers in the pool, where “work-related provider” was defined as either a coworker or a work-related contact (and not a social acquaintance).

Respondent characteristics. We use a dichotomous variable for respondent’s sex (1 = female, 0 = male), marital status (1 = married, 0 = not married), and the presence of young children (younger than six years old) in the household (1 = yes, 0 = no). Controls for marital status and the presence of children are important, as previous research has demonstrated that these factors influence time workers spend with coworkers, thereby affecting network size and composition (McGuire 2000; Wellman 1985). Two dummy variables capture differences across three educational categories: (1) whether the respondent has a graduate degree (the omitted category), (2) whether the respondent has a four-year college degree, and (3) whether the respondent has less than a four-year degree (i.e., “some college”). Occupational experience is a continuous measure describing the number of years the respondent

has worked in his or her present occupation (this is a measure of general human capital). Finally, to control for differences between full-time and part-time workers, respondents were asked about the number of hours typically worked per week at their last position.

Occupational sex composition. To control for unmeasured, but potentially important, factors associated with the sex composition of occupations, we computed the proportion female in each respondent's occupation using data from the 1997 Current Population Survey (March file). The Current Population Survey is a monthly survey of approximately 50,000 households conducted by the U.S. Census Bureau and is a primary source of data on characteristics of the U.S. labor force. We appended the sex composition variable to our data set by using the respondents' three-digit census occupational code. Descriptive statistics and bivariate correlations are reported in Tables 1 and 2, respectively.

Analyses

Our analysis is relatively straightforward and hinges on the association between the average job lead salaries and the measured attributes of the pool of tip providers, both with and without controls for respondent-level characteristics and their occupational attributes. Subsequently, we explore whether the effect of the sex composition of the tip provider pool has different effects for women and men. This provides a test of whether the quality of information gleaned through a contact depends on the sex of the job lead recipient. In other words, is the usefulness of personal contacts in providing job information conditional on the respondents' sex? We use ordinary least squares regression to estimate the parameters of our models.

RESULTS

Is It Who You Know?

The first regression model in Table 3 includes only the dummy variable for sex (female = 1); it gives the gross mean gender difference in average salaries of job leads received by the respondent. Without controlling for respondent characteristics, social network attributes, or sex segregation of the respondents' occupation, men receive job leads averaging \$52,743 (the intercept). The gross gender gap in job lead salary is significant and indicates that women receive leads averaging \$45,843 (\$52,743 - \$6,900), or 13 percent lower than those received by men. This gross mean sex difference is also evident in Table 1.

Model 2 includes controls for labor supply or the human capital factors of education, occupational experience, marital status, number of hours worked, and the presence of young children (younger than six years old) in the household. In this

TABLE 1: Descriptive Statistics and *t*-Tests for Variables in the Analysis

	<i>Mean</i>	<i>Standard Deviation</i>	<i>Range</i>
Entire sample			
Mean salary of job leads	50,417	22,248	0-118,000
Female	.34	.47	0-1
Proportion female in tipster pool	.31	.37	0-1
Number of work-related tipsters	1.86	1.00	0-3
Education			
Some college	.26	.44	0-1
College degree	.45	.50	0-1
Graduate degree	.29	.45	0-1
Married	.49	.50	0-1
Hours worked	47.28	12.22	5-90
Occupational experience	15.12	9.30	1.5-40
Occupation proportion female	.53	.25	0-.99
Young children in household	.08	.34	0-2
Men			
Mean salary of job leads	52,743	22,371	1-118,000
Proportion female in tipster pool	.21	.32	0-1
Number of work-related tipsters	1.85	1.02	0-3
Education			
Some college	.23	.42	0-1
College degree	.47	.50	0-1
Graduate degree	.29	.46	0-1
Married	.59	.49	0-1
Hours worked	48.75	11.18	5-90
Occupational experience	15.88	9.48	1.5-40
Occupation proportion female	.51	.26	0-.92
Young children in household	.11	.39	0-2
Women			
Mean salary of job leads	45,843**	21,460	1-102,500
Proportion female in tipster pool	.50***	.39	0-1
Number of work-related tipsters	1.86	.97	0-3
Education			
Some college	.32	.47	0-1
College degree	.41	.49	0-1
Graduate degree	.27	.45	0-1
Married	.31***	.46	0-1
Hours worked	44.39**	13.70	10-75
Occupational experience	13.61	8.82	2-30
Occupation proportion female	.57*	.22	.09-.99
Young children in household	.03	.18	0-1

NOTE: *N* = 175.For test of sex difference in means, **p* < .10. ***p* < .05. ****p* < .01.

model, the female disadvantage in job leads declines by more than \$3,000 and is no longer significant (*p* > .05). Sex differences in the variables included in model 2 explain more than half (55 percent) of the gross mean sex gap in the quality of job

TABLE 2: Bivariate Correlations for Variables Used in the Analysis

<i>Variable</i>	<i>1</i>	<i>2</i>	<i>3</i>	<i>4</i>	<i>5</i>	<i>6</i>	<i>7</i>	<i>8</i>	<i>9</i>	<i>10</i>	<i>11</i>
1. Gender (female = 1)	—										
2. Occupational experience	-.12	—									
3. Education: Some college	.10	.09	—								
4. Education: College degree	-.06	-.03	-.54***	—							
5. Married (1 = yes)	-.27***	.27***	-.07	.06	—						
6. Hours worked	-.16**	.06	-.04	-.05	.02	—					
7. Children younger than six (1 = yes)	-.11	-.08	-.11	.04	.15*	.11	—				
8. Number of work-related tipsters	.01	.12	.02	.01	.08	-.06	-.08	—			
9. Tipster pool proportion female	.38***	-.14*	.01	-.01	-.10	-.08	-.01	.11	—		
10. Occupation percentage female	.11	-.13*	-.09	.09	-.06	.04	-.07	-.11	.12	—	
11. Average job lead wage	-.15**	.30***	-.08	-.06	.17*	.22***	-.12*	-.10	-.23***	-.10	—

NOTE: $N = 175$.* $p < .10$. ** $p < .05$. *** $p < .01$.

TABLE 3: Ordinary Least Squares Regression Models Predicting Average Salary of Job Leads Received, Unstandardized Coefficients

<i>Variable</i>	<i>Model 1</i>	<i>Model 2</i>	<i>Model 3</i>	<i>Model 4</i>	<i>Model 5</i>
Intercept	52,743***	30,057***	34,043***	37,344***	33,985***
Job leads pooled characteristics					
Number of work-related tipsters	—	—	–538	–719	–598
Proportion female leads	—	—	–10,362**	–10,230**	–3,541
Gender interaction					
Female × Pool Proportion Female	—	—	—		–15,857*
Occupational sex composition					
Proportion female in occupation	—	—	—	–6,461	–4,516
Respondent characteristics					
Gender (female = 1)	–6,900**	–3,121	39	329	6,266
Occupational experience	—	608***	573***	555***	571***
Education					
Some college	—	–9,348**	–9,538**	–9,721**	–9,288**
College degree	—	–6,749*	–6,775*	–6,527*	–6,561*
Married (1 = yes)	—	4,585	4,853	4,916	5,191
Hours worked	—	346***	338***	348***	354***
Children younger than six 6 years old (1 = yes)	—	–10,480**	–10,311**	–10,761**	–11,178**
R^2	.02	.17	.22	.23	.25
F	3.82**	5.62***	5.13***	4.72***	4.61***

NOTE: Standard errors are not shown but are available on request. $N = 175$ in all models. Dashes indicate no entry for variable.

* $p < .10$. ** $p < .05$. *** $p < .01$.

leads. Based on the first two models, it appears that men receive superior job leads in part because they differ from women with respect to experience, education, and the other variables included in model 2. Also noteworthy is the fact that both women and men with relatively high levels of experience and number of hours worked tend to receive better leads than those with lower levels of experience and who work fewer hours per week. In addition, net of the other variables, respondents with young children in their households receive significantly lower salaried leads than do those with no children or children older than six. This large negative net effect of young children on job lead quality persists across all five regression models.⁹ This interesting and unanticipated finding, which deserves more attention in future research, suggests that individuals might reserve their best job leads for workers without young children.¹⁰ Alternatively, this finding could reflect variation in factors we were unable to control; for example, if individuals with young children spend less time interacting with coworkers and more time socializing with community members, this could result in lower-quality job leads.¹¹

The positive effects of experience and hours worked is not explained by workers' having more male, work-related tip providers. Model 3 indicates that these variables remain significant and positive even after controlling for the number of work-related job lead providers and the sex composition (percentage female) of the respondent's tip provider pool. Net of respondent characteristics, the type of contact (work-related versus social acquaintance) does not influence job lead salary. However, those with more women in their tip provider pool receive significantly lower salary tips. The results from model 3 suggest that men tend to be better sources of job-related information than women—the benefit of having male contacts exists over and above the measured human capital differences across respondents. Of course, women and men occupy different structural locations in work establishments, even when comparing individuals with similar human capital profiles. This could explain why men are better lead providers than women are. Not only does model 3 not control for occupational characteristics, but it also is likely that given a particular level of occupational experience, men hold more desirable jobs than women. Thus, job leads received from men can reflect this advantage despite the fact that occupational experience, and other factors, is held constant.

Model 4 adds the sex composition (percentage female) of the respondent's occupation. Notably, the negative effect of a female-dominated tip provider pool in model 3 is not explained by the sex composition of the respondent's occupation. Comparing the effect of the sex composition of the tip provider pool across models 3 and 4 suggests that differences in tips received (by both sexes) from women are not due to the occupational segregation of women; however, this result is probably due to the high degree of job-level segregation found within occupations (e.g., Groshen 1991). Thus, because women are concentrated in jobs with relatively low prestige and pay, even within gender-balanced occupations, they tend to pass on job leads lower in quality than men's job leads (Drentea 1998).

Is It Who You Are?

Models 1 through 4 considered only the main effects of the job lead pooled characteristics. That is, the effects of these variables are constrained to be the same for male and female respondents. Therefore, they do not address the possibility that those characteristics might have different effects for men and women job seekers. As noted above, there are two possible explanations for the sex gap in job lead quality. First, women might simply have fewer high-quality (male) job lead providers than do men. This explanation means that the respondents' gender matters only insofar as it determines their network composition. Here, the sex differences in the quality of job leads received by women and men are reduced to differences in the composition of their personal networks. The second explanation, informed by status construction theory and research in relational demography, posits an interaction between the recipient's gender and the sex composition of the lead provider pool. This relatively untested possibility is based on the idea that tip providers condition their job leads on the sex of the person to whom they are providing the lead. We test this proposition in model 5.

The results suggest a marginally significant difference in the effect of tip provider pool sex composition for male and female respondents ($p = .09$). The nature of this interaction was unanticipated, however. Model 5 indicates that for men, the net effect of the proportion of women in their tipster pool is $-3,541$, which is not statistically significant. Thus, men receive approximately the same quality job tips from male and female tip providers, controlling for other variables in the model. In contrast, for women, the effect of the proportion female in the tipster pool is large, significant, and negative (among women, the effect is $-3,541 + -15,857 = -19,398$, $p < .01$). Thus, for women, an increase in the percentage female in the tip provider pool results in significantly lower-quality job leads. To illustrate this relationship, the sex-specific associations between tipster pool sex composition and average job leads are depicted in Figure 1.

DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

In this article, we have taken a new approach to the study of the role of gender in social contacts and the job search by examining the overall quality of job lead information as a function of both the job lead provider and the recipient. This approach differs from previous research on job leads because it considers the job lead itself as the focus of investigation rather than the association between a single successful job lead and a job search outcome such as earnings. Our unique data set allows us to examine three dimensions of the process of job lead transmission: the who you know dimension, the who you are dimension, and the interaction between them.

Our findings suggest that who you know clearly matters. Predictably, respondents with relatively high levels of occupational experience and who work many

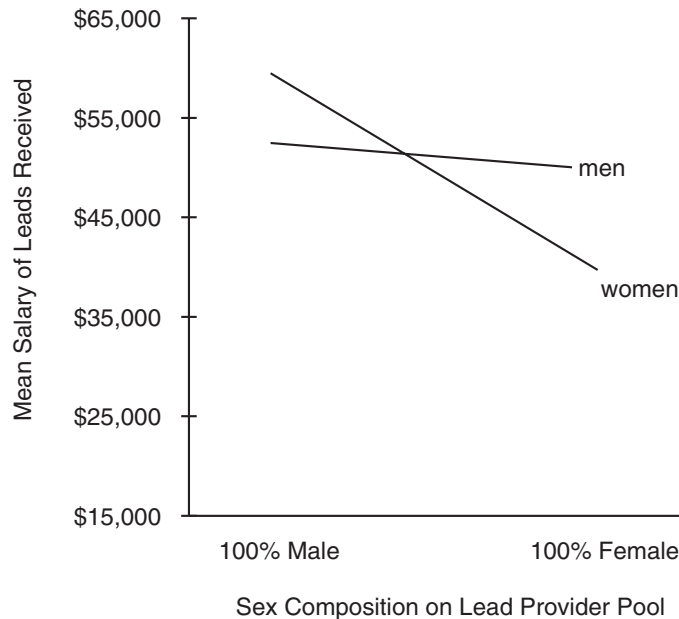


Figure 1: Association between Sex Composition of Pool of Job Lead Providers and Mean Salary of Leads Received, by Sex

NOTE: The plot is based on model 5 in Table 3. Predicted values are for married college degree holders with mean values on all continuous independent variables.

hours per week received higher-quality leads than other respondents, a finding that almost certainly reflects the advantaged positions of these respondents' job lead providers. Who you know also matters in explaining why female respondents receive lower-quality job leads than their male counterparts. At the zero-order level, women receive job leads of significantly lower quality and have significantly more women in their tip provider pools than do men. However, when other factors are controlled (see Model 4 in Table 3), the effect of percentage female in the tip provider pool remained significant and negative, which is probably a consequence of job-level segregation—women provide lower-quality job leads because they occupy lower status jobs, regardless of the sex composition of their occupation. This finding should be of particular interest to both researchers and policy makers interested in the consequences of sex segregation in the workplace. However, to the extent that lead providers condition their leads on the sex of the recipient, desegregating jobs, occupations, and personal networks may be only part of the answer because integration only addresses the structural, or who you know, part of the problem. Inequality also results from more complex, interactional dynamics based on beliefs about gender-appropriate work roles, which are often beyond the reach of gender-neutral organizational policies (Ridgeway 1997). Ridgeway (1997, 232)

argued that only policies that actively redress gender discrimination, such as affirmative action, will reduce the interactional component of inequality by increasing employers' accountability and creating "stereotype-disconfirming" experiences.¹²

Our findings regarding respondents' sex, or who you are, are provocative and warrant further examination. Job lead providers are aware of the sex of the person to whom they are providing a lead—a significant body of literature has demonstrated how widely held beliefs are organized around attributes such as gender, leading to the assumption that men are more competent than women and are therefore entitled to scarce rewards such as well-paying jobs (Ridgeway 1997, 222). If this were true, we would hypothesize that male lead providers hold out when providing job-related information to women; thus, men's advantage gained from having male contacts would be larger than women's. Instead, we found that the effect of percentage female in respondents' lead provider pools was negative for women and essentially zero for men.

What might be occurring is that women and men are making different valuations about the worth of the job (rather than the worthiness of contacts), and factors other than salary may be part of those valuations. For example, the negative effect for women could be due to the fact that the leads offered by women to other women are for jobs that offer better opportunities for balancing work-family demands. To the extent that such jobs are relatively low paying (possibly part-time or contingent work), leads given to women by women may reflect the difficult trade-offs that women often face in the labor market. It may be the case that women have different kinds of conversations with their female contacts that involve more nuanced evaluations of jobs. Unfortunately, because we are limited to salary information as our measure of job lead quality, we cannot fully explore this possibility. Clearly, our findings call for the collection of qualitative interview data on gender and how it relates to the process of passing along job information. This would be the best way to uncover the mechanisms producing the patterns revealed in our analyses.

Differences in the types of networks actively sought out by women and men might explain the interaction between respondents' sex and the sex composition of their personal networks in other ways as well. In her study of an advertising firm, Ibarra (1992) found that women experienced "a differentiated network pattern in which they obtained social support and friendship from women and instrumental access through networks of men" (p. 422). Thus, if women are seeking out other women primarily as contacts for social support (even when those contacts are work related) and men allow women into their networks only when they are useful for instrumental purposes, then men would suffer less disadvantage from having women in their networks than would women. This points to a selection process by which men default to other men when seeking job leads and seek out only exceptionally positioned women from whom to glean job-related information. Men may include women in their networks only when they are perceived as acceptable surrogates for male lead providers. Our findings conform to this pattern—all else being equal, men who received leads only from women fared much better than women who received leads only from women.

Although preliminary, we hope that this research will inspire future data collection that will address the quality of job-related information transmitted through individuals' personal contacts. Existing research would greatly benefit from data collection that addresses the work-related networks of racial and ethnic minorities. This would allow one to investigate whether status value beliefs about women and racial/ethnic minorities operate similarly. Those kinds of data collection efforts would greatly improve our understanding of the role played by personal networks in both matching workers to jobs and reproducing both gender and racial work-based inequality.

NOTES

1. Research on relational demography is also relevant with respect to the direct effect of individual attributes (e.g., Tsui, Egan, and O'Reilly 1992; Tsui and Farh 1997). The central issue in this body of research is the extent to which demographic similarities or differences between individuals condition the behaviors of group members toward each other. This research has extended Pfeffer's (1983) groundbreaking work on organizational demography.

2. In 1997, the unemployment rate in California ranged between 7 and 8 percent. Employees in aerospace and other high-technology industries were especially affected by layoffs.

3. At the time of our data collection, 1 club was in the process of merging with another, so the total number of active clubs was 25.

4. Survey participation was voluntary.

5. Because club membership is fluid, accurately estimating the denominator on which to base the individual-level response rate is extremely difficult. On one hand, the club coordinators reported to us that "nearly all" of those who were present at the meeting when the surveys were distributed completed the questionnaire. Thus, if the number present at the time the survey was distributed is used as the denominator, the response rate is significantly higher than 60 percent. On the other hand, if the coordinator's estimate of the typical weekly attendance at the meetings is used, the response rate is closer to 55 percent. We think that 60 percent is a very conservative estimate of the response rate, as best as it can be computed.

6. On average, our respondents are only slightly older than comparable workers in California. Also, respondents work several hours longer per week, are less likely to be married, and are more likely to have a graduate degree. Our sample is also more heavily male dominated than one would expect in a random sample. However, the distribution of race (white vs. nonwhite) is quite similar to the Current Population Survey data set.

7. The majority of respondents reported being unemployed for less than several months.

8. We are interested in explaining variation in the quality of job lead information, where the lead itself is implicitly the unit of analysis. Whether certain kinds of tips changed the likelihood of a job match is an interesting, but different, question that we do not address here. In previous research (Torres and Huffman 2002), we used the data set analyzed here to explore the more traditional question of how particular kinds of contacts influence the quality of a job match (e.g., salary). The analysis presented here is fundamentally distinct in that we examine overall job lead quality rather than how different kinds of contacts increase or lower the probability of a high-quality job match.

9. Some of the effect of young children might be an age effect. This would be the case if being young increases the likelihood of having both young children and young tip providers, who hold relatively low-paying jobs. Thus, age could account for the negative effect of young children. To test this, we estimated all five regression models controlling for respondent's age. We found no significant effect of age in any model, and its inclusion did not substantially alter the effect of any other independent variable.

10. In a supplementary model (not reported in the tables), we allowed the variable measuring the presence of young children to interact with respondent's gender to test whether the presence of young children has a stronger negative effect on job leads received by women than by men. This model yielded a nonsignificant interaction, suggesting that net of other variables in Model 5 of Table 3, the negative effect of young children on job lead quality is the same for women and men.

11. We thank a *Gender & Society* reviewer for making this point.

12. Konrad and Linnehan (1995) have also shown the importance of "identity conscious" workplace policies for increasing the employment opportunities of women and racial minorities.

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